



The Recruiting Compass

FREE PARENT GUIDE · ANY SPORT

The College Recruiting Timeline

Grades 9–12

A parent's checklist for every sport — what to do each year, the NCAA and NAIA dates that matter, and the words to use with coaches.

HOW TO USE THIS

1. Find your athlete's grade and check off items as you go — being ahead or behind is normal.
2. Rules differ by division and sport: use the Key Dates page, then confirm your sport's calendar.
3. Let your athlete lead. Your job: organize, ask good questions and keep the deadlines.

INSIDE

Year-by-year checklists · Key dates by division · Coach email template · 10 questions to ask a coach

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Freshman year: build the foundation

Grades start counting now. Coaches can't do much yet — but you can.

■ ACADEMICS

- ☐ Tell the school counselor your athlete hopes to play in college.
- ☐ Get the school's list of **NCAA-approved core courses** and plan all four years around it.
- ☐ Remember: every core-course grade from 9th grade on counts toward the NCAA core-course GPA.
- ☐ Create a free **Profile Page** account at eligibilitycenter.org if you haven't yet.

■ ATHLETICS

- ☐ Focus on development, fundamentals and staying healthy — not rankings.
- ☐ Start a simple log of stats, results, teams and coaches' contact info.
- ☐ Save game and practice video clips as the season goes.
- ☐ Ask your current coach for an honest read on strengths and next steps.

■ COMMUNICATION WITH COACHES

- ☐ Start a wide list of colleges across NCAA D1, D2, D3, NAIA and junior college.
- ☐ Fill out recruiting questionnaires on college team websites.
- ☐ Your athlete can email coaches any time — but some D1 coaches aren't allowed to reply yet.
- ☐ Choose camps with purpose: go where your athlete could realistically play.

■ FAMILY TO-DOS

- ☐ Set up one place for transcripts, schedules, awards and recruiting notes.
- ☐ Talk about goals: what matters beyond the sport — majors, distance, size, cost.
- ☐ Review social media together; coaches and admissions offices look.
- ☐ Keep it fun. A kid who still loves the sport will outwork any plan.

PARENT TIP

"Let your athlete send the emails — coaches notice who writes them. We proofread; we don't press send."

Sophomore year: get on the radar

For most NCAA Division I sports, June 15 after this year is when coaches can start reaching out.

■ ACADEMICS

- ☐ Stay on track for Division I's **10/7 rule**: 10 of 16 core courses — 7 in English, math or science — done before senior year starts. Those grades lock in.
- ☐ Check core-course progress with the counselor each semester.
- ☐ Ask the counselor to upload the transcript to the Eligibility Center at year's end.
- ☐ Consider a practice PSAT or PreACT. The NCAA no longer requires test scores, but some colleges still use them.

■ ATHLETICS

- ☐ Make a short highlight video — best clips first, your athlete clearly identified.
- ☐ Build a one-page athletic résumé: grad year, position/event, key stats, GPA, schedule, coach references.
- ☐ Compete at the highest level that fits — school, club, showcases or meets.
- ☐ Pick camps at schools on your list, not just famous ones.

■ COMMUNICATION WITH COACHES

- ☐ Email coaches an introduction with video, résumé and upcoming schedule.
- ☐ Include name, grad year, position and NCAA ID once you have one.
- ☐ Circle **June 15 after sophomore year** — most D1 sports can call, text and email from then on.
- ☐ Follow up after each new result; short updates beat long letters.

■ FAMILY TO-DOS

- ☐ Take regular admissions tours at a few nearby colleges of different sizes.
- ☐ Run each college's net price calculator to see what it might really cost.
- ☐ Start a simple tracker: school, coach, last contact, next step.
- ☐ Narrow and refresh the college list based on honest feedback.

PARENT TIP

"Keep the list wide. Great fits exist at every level — D1, D2, D3, NAIA and junior college — and some of the best are schools you almost didn't email."

Junior year: the big recruiting year

Visits open, conversations get real, and junior grades carry the most weight.

■ ACADEMICS

- ☐ Being recruited by D1 or D2? Upgrade to an **Academic and Athletics Certification** account — required for D1 official visits and to sign an athletics aid agreement.
- ☐ Confirm with the counselor that the 10/7 courses are done before senior year.
- ☐ Take the SAT/ACT if your target colleges want it for admission or merit aid.
- ☐ Ask the counselor to upload the transcript again after junior year.

■ ATHLETICS

- ☐ Update the highlight video with junior-season footage.
- ☐ Prioritize camps and events where interested coaches will be watching.
- ☐ Ask your club or high-school coach which level they honestly see your athlete at.
- ☐ Keep stats and results current — coaches ask for them.

■ COMMUNICATION WITH COACHES

- ☐ Answer calls, texts and emails promptly — and let your athlete do the talking.
- ☐ Share your NCAA ID with schools recruiting you so they can add you to their list.
- ☐ Plan official and unofficial visits once your sport and division allow them.
- ☐ Take notes after every conversation. Verbal offers and commitments aren't binding.

■ FAMILY TO-DOS

- ☐ Compare schools on academics, roster spot, coaching staff and total cost.
- ☐ Gather tax returns and savings info now for next fall's FAFSA and CSS Profile.
- ☐ Register at PlayNAIA.org if NAIA schools are on the list.
- ☐ Budget time and money for visits over the summer before senior year.

PARENT TIP

"Ask every coach, 'Where does my athlete stand on your list?' A clear answer — or a vague one — tells you where to spend your time."

Senior year: decide, sign, finish strong

Applications, aid and the final decision — plus paperwork that can't slip.

■ ACADEMICS

- ☐ Finish the remaining core courses; senior grades still count.
- ☐ Apply for admission — NCAA certification is **not** acceptance to a college.
- ☐ From **April 1** (fall enrollees), request final athletics certification in the Eligibility Center.
- ☐ After graduation, have the counselor upload the final transcript with proof of graduation.

■ ATHLETICS

- ☐ Stay healthy and keep competing — coaches still watch senior seasons.
- ☐ Not recruited yet? It's not too late at every level. Keep emailing with fresh results.
- ☐ Send updated video and stats to schools still in the running.
- ☐ Ask about summer workouts and what's expected before arrival.

■ COMMUNICATION WITH COACHES

- ☐ The National Letter of Intent is gone; D1 and D2 athletes now sign an **athletics aid agreement**.
- ☐ Read it closely: what's covered, one-year or multiyear, renewal terms.
- ☐ You can sign with only one school; other D1 and D2 schools must then stop recruiting you.
- ☐ Thank the coaches you turn down. It's a small world.

■ FAMILY TO-DOS

- ☐ File the **FAFSA** early — it opens by Oct. 1 — and note state and college deadlines.
- ☐ Complete the **CSS Profile** (opens Oct. 1) if a college on your list requires it.
- ☐ Compare aid offers side by side: athletic, academic and need-based.
- ☐ Remember: D3 schools don't offer athletics scholarships, but may offer academic or need-based aid.

PARENT TIP

"Pick the school your athlete would still love if the sport ended tomorrow. Injuries and coaching changes happen — the fit should outlast both."

REFERENCE

Key dates to know

General rules as of October 2026. Many sports have their own dates, plus “dead” and “quiet” periods — always check your sport’s current calendar.

DIVISION	WHEN COACHES CAN REACH OUT	CAMPUS VISITS	WORTH KNOWING
NCAA D1 most sports	Questionnaires and camp info any time. Calls, texts, emails and verbal offers from June 15 after sophomore year ; in-person, off-campus contact from Aug. 1 before junior year.	Official and unofficial visits from Aug. 1 before junior year .	Football, men’s and women’s basketball, baseball, softball, lacrosse and men’s ice hockey use different dates.
NCAA D2	Recruiting materials and communication (calls, texts, email) are allowed any time.	Official visits after June 15 before junior year .	In-person, off-campus contact also opens June 15 before junior year.
NCAA D3	No recruiting calendars. Coaches generally have more freedom to communicate.	Unofficial visits any time; ask coaches when official visits are allowed.	No athletics scholarships; academic and need-based aid may be available.
NAIA	No recruiting calendar — athletes and coaches can communicate year-round.	Few restrictions; ask each program.	Register with the NAIA Eligibility Center at PlayNAIA.org .

NCAA eligibility milestones (D1 and D2)

Grade 9 or earlier	Create an Eligibility Center Profile Page account; the NCAA suggests registering before ninth grade.	When recruited	Upgrade to an Academic and Athletics Certification account (fee or waiver).
All 4 years	16 NCAA-approved core courses. Minimum core GPA: 2.3 (D1), 2.2 (D2).	Before grade 12	D1 10/7 rule: 10 core courses done, 7 of them English, math or science.
End of 10th & 11th	Counselor uploads official transcripts to the Eligibility Center.	Test scores	No longer required for NCAA D1/D2 eligibility (since 2023). Colleges may still ask.
Oct. 1, grade 12	FAFSA open (it launches by Oct. 1; 2027–28 opened in Sept. 2026). CSS Profile opens Oct. 1.	Apr. 1, grade 12	Fall enrollees can request final athletics (amateurism) certification.

As of October 2026 — rules change. Confirm your sport’s dates with the NCAA and each school’s compliance office.

Email to a coach: a simple template

Short, specific and written by your athlete. Send it to the position or event coach and copy the head coach.

Subject: [Grad year] [Position/Event] · [First Last] · [Club / High School] · [City, State]

Coach [Last name] ,

My name is [First Last] , a [grad year] [position/event] at [High School] and [Club] . I'm very interested in [College] because [one specific reason — major, style of play, team culture] .

This season I [1–2 key stats or results] . My GPA is [x.xx] and I plan to study [major/interest] .

Highlight video: [link]

Upcoming schedule: [event, date, location]

NCAA ID: [number] · Coach reference: [name, phone, email]

I'd love to learn what you look for in a [position/event] and whether I could be a fit. Thank you for your time.

— [First Last] · [phone] · [email]

Personalize

One real reason for each school. Coaches spot copy-paste instantly.

Keep it short

A coach should get the picture in 30 seconds on a phone.

Follow up

No reply? Send a brief update with new results in 2–3 weeks.

Questions to ask a college coach

- 1 Where does my athlete stand on your recruiting list for this class?
- 2 How many players at this position or event are you recruiting this year?
- 3 What does a typical day look like in season and out of season?
- 4 How do you decide playing time, and how do freshmen usually fit in?
- 5 Is athletic aid part of this offer? Is it one-year or multiyear, and how is renewal decided?
- 6 What academic support do athletes get, and can they fit my athlete's intended major?
- 7 What are the team's graduation rate and culture like? Can we talk to current players?
- 8 What happens to my athlete's spot and aid after an injury?
- 9 How long do you plan to be here, and what happens if the staff changes?
- 10 What is your timeline for decisions, and what are the next steps for us?

FACT-CHECK

Sources

Every rule and date in this guide comes from the sources below, checked in late September 2026.

1. NCAA, 2026–27 Guide for the College-Bound Student-Athlete (Eligibility Center accounts, registration timing, core courses, 10/7 rule, GPA minimums, test scores, transcripts, final certification, athletics aid agreements, official and unofficial visits, D3 scholarships): http://fs.ncaa.org/Docs/eligibility_center/Student_Resources/CBSA.pdf
2. NCAA, Division I initial-eligibility requirements: <https://www.ncaa.org/eligibility-center/initial-eligibility-requirements/division-i/>
3. NCAA, Initial-eligibility requirements overview (D1 2.3 / D2 2.2 core GPA): <https://www.ncaa.org/eligibility-center/initial-eligibility-requirements/>
4. NCAA Legislative Services Database, Division I Proposal 2018–93 (June 15 after sophomore year; Aug. 1 before junior year for visits; excluded sports): <https://web3.ncaa.org/lisdbi/search/proposalView?id=103278>
5. NCAA, Division I Recruiting Guide for sports other than football and basketball (sport-by-sport exceptions): https://ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/compliance/recruiting/calendar/2022-23/2022-23D1REC_OtherSportsRecruitingGuide.pdf
6. NCAA, Division II Coaches Off-Campus Recruiting Guide 2026–27: https://ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/compliance/recruiting/calendar/2026-27/2026-27D2REC_RecGuide.pdf
7. NCAA, Division I sport recruiting calendars 2026–27 (dead and quiet periods): <https://ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/compliance/recruiting/calendar/2026-27/>
8. ESPN, “NCAA approves elimination of national letter of intent program” (Oct. 2024): https://www.espn.com/college-sports/story/_/id/41702974/ncaa-approves-elimination-national-letter-intent-program
9. NAIA, Parents page (no recruiting calendar; register at PlayNAIA): <https://www.naia.org/findyourpath/parents/index>
10. NAIA, Guide for the College-Bound Student-Athlete (few contact restrictions): https://play.mynaia.org/media/1091/naia_guide_college_bound_student.pdf
11. U.S. Department of Education, “2027–28 FAFSA Form Now Available” (Sept. 23, 2026): <https://financialaidtoolkit.ed.gov/tk/announcement-detail.jsp?id=fafsa-updates>
12. Federal Student Aid, FAFSA support announcements: <https://studentaid.gov/announcements-events/fafsa-support>
13. College Board, About CSS Profile (opens Oct. 1; institutional aid): <https://cssprofile.collegeboard.org/about>

As of October 2026 — rules change. Confirm your sport’s dates with the NCAA (ncaa.org recruiting calendars) and each school’s compliance office. General information only — not eligibility advice, and no promise of a roster spot or scholarship.

Keep every school, coach and deadline in one place.

This checklist gets you started. The Recruiting Compass keeps it going — an organizer built for parents of high-school athletes in any sport.

- Track every school on your list and where it stands
- Log coach calls, emails and visits so nothing falls through
- See upcoming deadlines and next steps at a glance

Founding Families: free for life.

therecruitingcompass.com

Available now on the web, iPhone and iPad